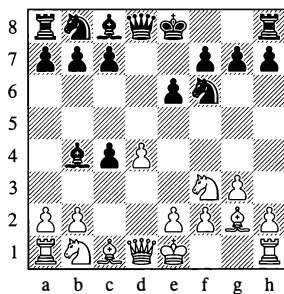


Chapter 4

Catalan 4...dxc4



5...♗b4†

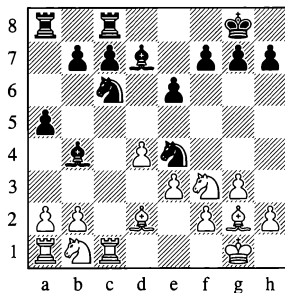
Variation Index

1.d4 ♘f6 2.c4 e6 3.g3 d5 4.♘f3 dxc4 5.♗g2 ♗b4†

6.♗d2

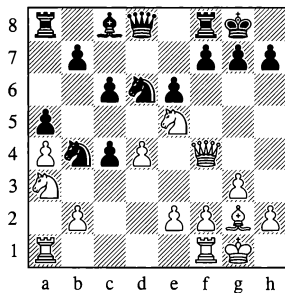
A) 6...♗xd2†	52
B) 6...c5	53
C) 6...♗e7	54
D) 6...a5 7.♖c2	56
D1) 7...♘c6	56
D2) 7...♗xd2† 8.♖xd2 c6 9.a4	57
D21) 9...♘e4	58
D22) 9...b5	59

D1) after 13...♞fc8?



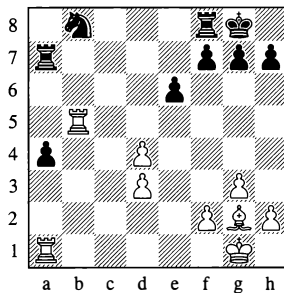
14.♗xb4!N

D21) after 13...♘b4



14.♞fd1!N

D22) note to 22...♞d8



23.d5!N

1.d4 ♘f6 2.c4 e6 3.g3 d5 4.♘f3 dxc4 5.♙g2 ♙b4†

Black's idea is simple: he intends to hold on to the c4-pawn for a while and so force White to waste time regaining it.

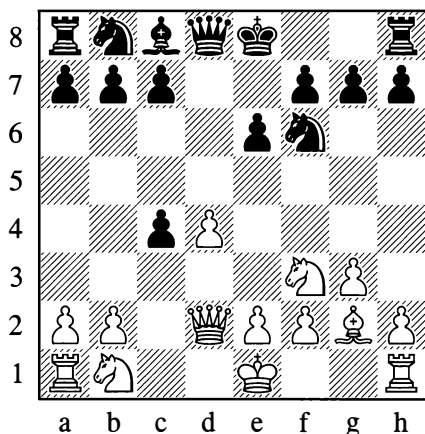
6.♙d2

Black has tried a lot of moves here. We shall look at the four important ones: A) 6...♙xd2†, B) 6...c5, C) 6...♙e7 and D) 6...a5.

A) 6...♙xd2†

This is not a popular choice at a high level, as White regains the pawn and keeps good positional pressure along the h1-a8 diagonal.

7.♞xd2



7...0-0

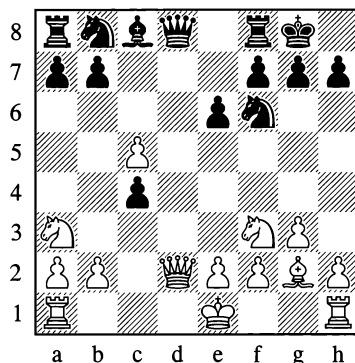
It is certainly important to know the following line: 7...b5 8.a4!N (In the only game in this position, Sosonko – Furman, Wijk aan Zee 1975, White played 8.♞g5 which is actually pretty unclear after 8...a6!N 9.♞xg7 ♞g8 10.♞h6 ♙b7 11.0-0 ♘bd7.) 8...c6 9.axb5 cxb5 10.♘c3 b4 (even worse for Black is 10...♞b6 11.♞g5 0-0 12.♞xb5 ♙b7 13.0-0± when White is clearly better) 11.♘b5 0-0 12.♞xb4 ♘d5 13.♞d6 The arising endgame will be a long-term torture for Black, due to his weak queenside pawns.

8.♘a3! ♞e7

The character of the game is not really changed by:

8...c5 9.dxc5

Obviously there is nothing wrong with 9.♘xc4.



9...♘a6

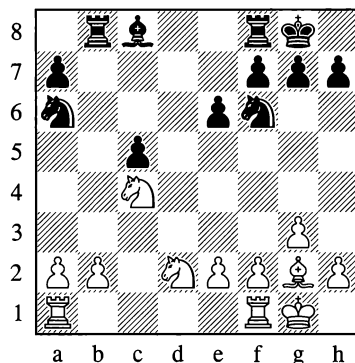
A good example of this variation is 9...♘e4 10.♞xd8 ♞xd8 11.♘xc4 ♘c6 12.0-0 ♘xc5 as in Lupor – Klundt, Bad Wiessee 2000, and there is no relief for Black even after the queen trade, so after the accurate 13.♞fd1N ♙d7 14.♞ac1± White's pressure is significant.

10.c6!?

A more original approach in this position, though White certainly would also be better after the natural 10.♘xc4.

10...bxc6 11.♘xc4 ♞b8 12.0-0 ♞xd2 13.♘fxd2 c5

This occurred in Ganguly – Li Bo, Qinhuangdao 2011, and White retains long-term pressure after the best line:

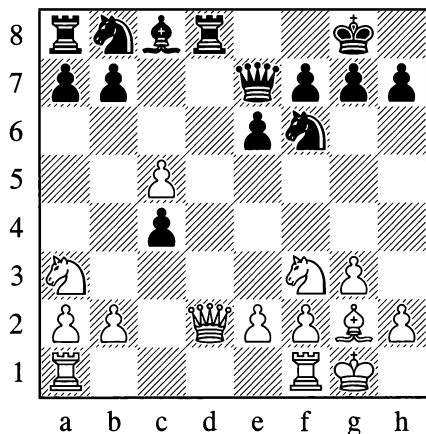


14.♟b3N ♟d7 15.♟fc1±

Black never has an easy life with this pawn structure.

9.0–0 c5 10.dxc5 ♟d8

10...♟xc5 11.♟ac1 is also nice for White.



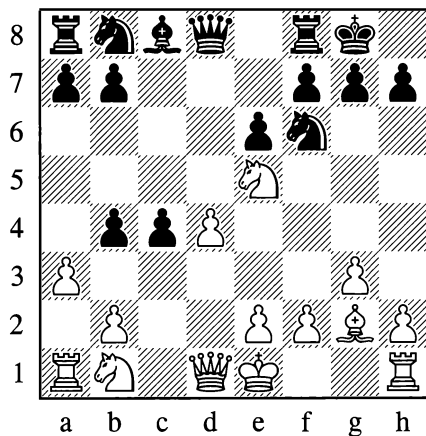
11.♟c3 ♟xc5 12.♟xc4 ♟xc4 13.♟xc4 ♟c6
14.♟fd1±

With a typical Catalan edge for White, as in Kharitonov – Kholmov, Moscow 1998.

B) 6...c5 7.♟xb4 cxb4 8.♟e5 0–0 9.a3!?

This is a big change compared to *GM 1*.

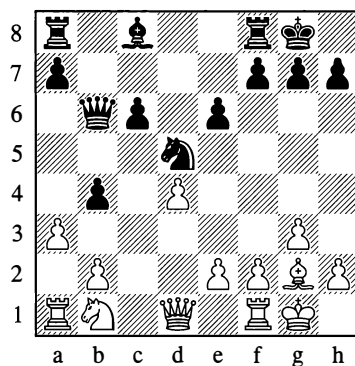
My recommendation 9.♟xc4 ♟c6 10.e3 has been tested quite a lot, and Black seems to be doing okay in this line by entering the sharp sequence 10...e5 11.d5 b5!.



9...♟c6

No one has tried 9...bxa3 which is understandable, since after 10.♟xa3 ♟d5 11.♟axc4 (11.♟exc4 ♟c6 12.0–0 ♟db4 13.e3± is also nice for White) 11...f6 12.♟d3 ♟c6 13.e3 b6 14.0–0 ♟b7 15.♟a4± White has a pleasant edge, which is exactly what he is aiming for.

9...♟d5 10.♟xc4 ♟c7 11.♟e5 ♟c6 12.♟xc6 bxc6 (if 12...♟xc6 13.0–0 ♟b6 14.♟d2 then White has a slight advantage) 13.0–0 ♟b6 This position occurred in Loginov – Hacker, corr. 2013.



I believe White should keep a slight edge after 14.♟d2N ♟d8 15.♟d1 ♟b8 16.axb4 ♟xb4 17.♟a3 ♟a6 18.♟c2 ♟d5 19.♟dc1 and from a human point of view, it seems White retains pressure due to Black's weak queenside structure.

9...♟c7 occurred in one computer game, when after 10.♟c2 ♟d5 11.♟xc4 ♟xc4 12.♟xc4 ♟c6 13.e3 White has a nagging pull in the arising endgame.

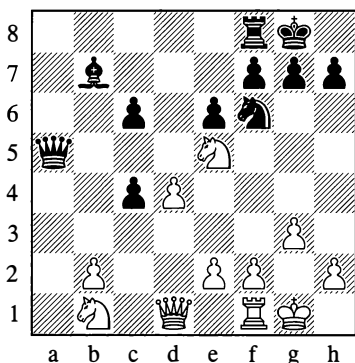
10.♟xc6

This was my original novelty, which was found during my work with Boris Gelfand. He managed to exploit my idea in his game versus Adams.

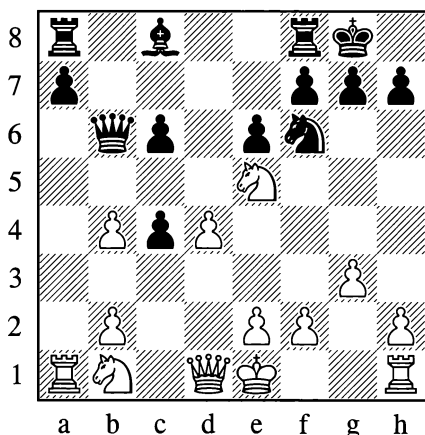
10. ♖xc6 bxc6 11. axb4 as in Bareev – Grachev, St Petersburg 2009, is unclear due to the improvement: 11... ♖b8!N

10...bxc6 11.axb4 ♖b6

The aforementioned game continued:
11... ♖b7 12.0-0 a5 13.bxa5 ♖xa5 14.♞xa5
♞xa5



15. ♞d2! A key move that clarifies White's advantage. 15... ♞a7 16. ♖xc4 ♞d8 (16...c5 doesn't change much after 17.dxc5 ♞xc5 18. ♖ba3± with an extra pawn) 17. ♞d1 c5 18. ♞a5 ♞xa5 19. ♖xa5 ♖a8 (19... ♖a6 20.e3 cxd4 21. ♖c6±) 20. ♖b3 cxd4 21. ♞xd4 ♞b8 22. ♖c5 g5 23. ♖c3± White convincingly converted his extra pawn in Gelfand – Adams, Eilat 2012.



12.0-0 ♞xb4 13.♞d2! c5 14.♞xb4 cxb4

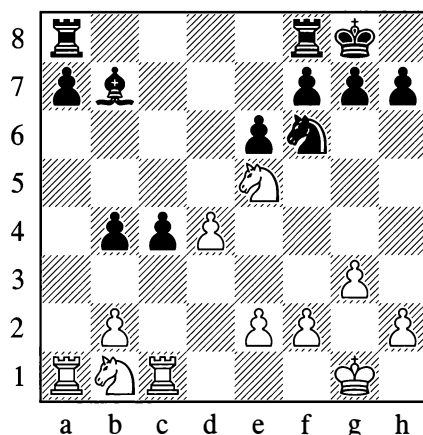
15.♞c1!

Now this works well for White.

15...♖b7

Black tried 15... ♖d5 in Baryshpolets – Simonian, Kiev 2013. Again I like 16. ♖xc4N ♖d7 17. ♖bd2 ♞fc8 18. ♖a5!± with a stable advantage.

In Baryshpolets – Munkhgal, Kazan 2013, White should have played:

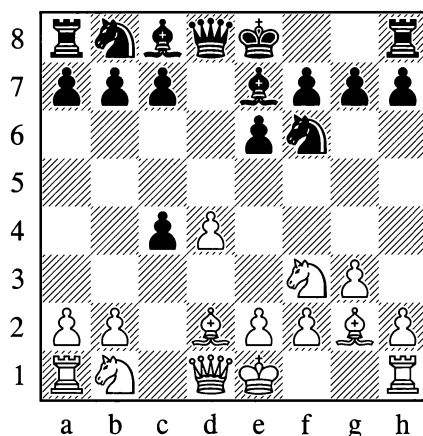


16.♖xc4N ♞fd8 17.♖a5! ♖e4 18.e3

White has a pleasant edge in this endgame.

C) 6...♖e7

This move does not impress me, but we should still know how to meet it.

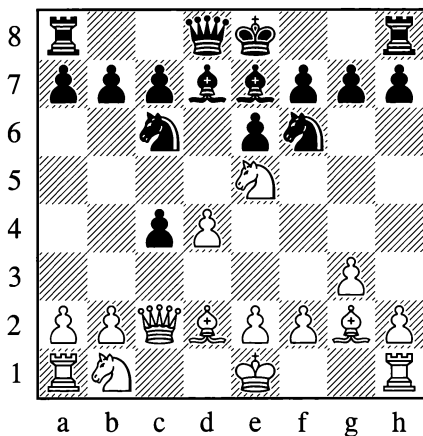


7.♙c2 ♖d7

In the event of 7...a6 8.♙xc4 b5 9.♙c2 ♖b7 10.0–0 we have a well-known position from the classical line of the Catalan with ...♙e7, but with an extra tempo for White; which is a serious achievement. 10...♙e4 (10...0–0 transposes to variation A of Chapter 13 on page 182) 11.♙c1 0–0 12.♙d1 ♖b7 13.♙f4 ♘d5 14.♘c3 ♘xf4 15.♙xf4 ♙d6 C. Horvath – Mochalov, Rethymnon 2003, is once again a theoretical position, but White's extra move ♙d1 is crucial to the evaluation. Now was the right time for 16.♘e5N ♙xg2 17.♙xg2 ♘d7 18.♘e4 with a nice positional pull.

8.♘e5 ♘c6

8...♙c6 has been tried only once: 9.♘xc6 ♘e3 e5 11.♙xc4 exd4 12.♙xc6† bxc6 13.♙xc6† ♙f8 14.0–0 White was better in Urbanek – V. Ivanov, email 2008.

**9.♙xc4 ♘xe5 10.dxe5 ♘d5 11.♙g4!**

With this structure White has to show some special ideas, and his last move definitely poses Black a major headache.

11...g6

11...0–0 12.♙h6± is hardly acceptable for Black, as he loses an exchange.

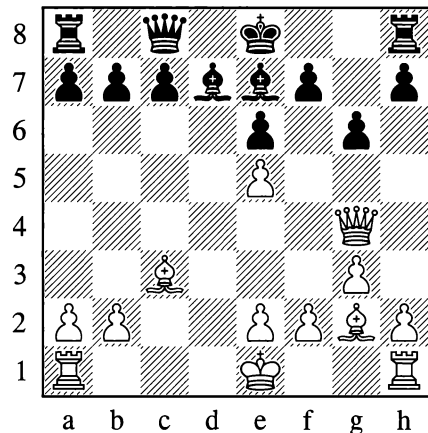
12.♘c3

12.♙h6 is not so efficient, as Black can go for queenside castling.

12...♘xc3 13.♙xc3 ♙c8

I also checked the natural 13...c6 when White has the same idea: 14.♙e4 ♙c7 (14...0–0 is dangerous in view of 15.h4 h5 16.♙f3± and 17.g4 is coming with great effect) 15.♙f3 ♙f8 16.0–0 0–0–0 17.b4† The black king is not safe on the queenside either.

This was played in Lemke – Bebersdorf, Germany 1995, and now a strong continuation would have been:

**14.♙e4!N c5**

14...0–0 15.♙f3 ♙b8 16.h4 is dangerous, as we already know.

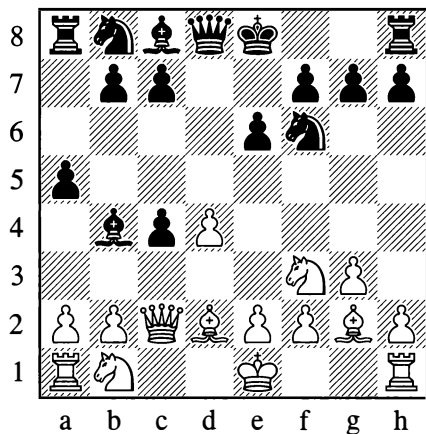
15.♙f3 ♙b8 16.h4 h5

Much worse is 16...0–0 17.h5 ♙c6 18.♙xc6 ♙xc6 19.♙xc6 bxc6 20.0–0–0± when strategically White is almost winning.

17.0–0–0

And it's not so clear how Black is going to solve his king issue.

D) 6...a5 7.♖c2



Another big change from *GM 1*. There I gave 7.0-0, but lately Black has been doing quite well after 7...0-0 8.♗g5 b5. We will now analyse D1) 7...♗c6 and the main line D2) 7...♗xd2†. But first there is a minor line to consider:

7...b5 8.a4 bxa4 (8...c6 is simply bad in view of 9.axb5 ♗xd2† 10.♗fxd2!. After 10...♖xd4 11.♖xc4 ♖b6 12.♗c3 ♗b7 13.♗a4! White had a substantial advantage in Gulko – Ljubojevic, Linares 1990.) 9.♗e5 ♗a6 10.♖xa4† ♗d7 11.♗xd7 ♖xd7 12.0-0 0-0 13.♖xd7 ♗fxd7 Tkachiev – Moiseenko, Santo Domingo 2002. White should have played 14.♗c1N c5 15.♗xc4 cxd4 16.♗xb4 axb4 17.♗xa6 ♗xa6 18.♗xd4 ♗dc5 19.♗d2± when his advantage is quite annoying.

D1) 7...♗c6 8.♖xc4 ♖d5

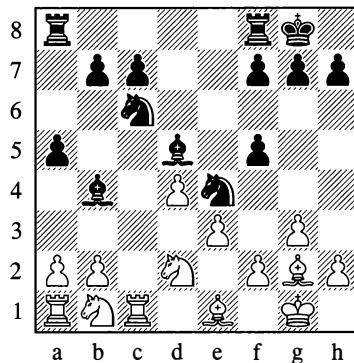
An old and well-known line, though White should be able to gain a pleasant edge:

9.♖d3 ♖e4

Black has other options:

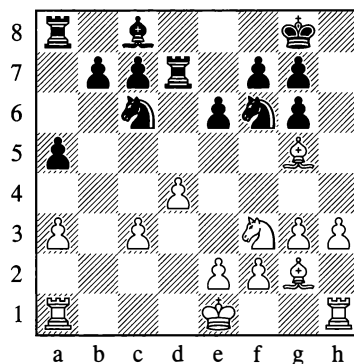
9...♖f5 10.♖xf5 exf5 11.0-0 ♗e6 12.♗c1 ♗d5 (12...0-0 has been played three times. Here I like the simple and natural 13.♗c3N a4

14.♗b5 ♗d6 15.e3 ♗d5 16.♗e1 with a slight edge.) 13.e3 ♗e4 14.♗e1 0-0 15.♗fd2 White preserves some pressure in this endgame, as was proven by:



15...♗fe8 16.♗c3! ♗xc3 17.bxc3 ♗xg2 18.cxb4 ♗d5 19.b5 ♗b4 20.a3 ♗d3 21.♗c3 ♗xe1 22.♗xe1 c6 23.♗b1± With a positional edge, Giri – Landa, Mulhouse 2011.

9...0-0?! 10.♗c3 ♖h5 11.h3! ♗d8 Black's strategy looks dubious and it's no surprise that White retains a solid advantage here. 12.a3 ♗xc3 (12...♗e7 can be met by 13.♗c1!, when it is not so clear how Black can move.) 13.bxc3 ♖g6 14.♖xg6 hxg6 15.♗g5 Even without queens, White's advantage is significant. 15...♗d7 occurred in Fridman – Bartel, Dresden 2008, and now I like:



16.♗e5!N ♗xe5 17.dxe5 ♗d5 18.c4 ♗b6 19.♗c1 White is clearly better.

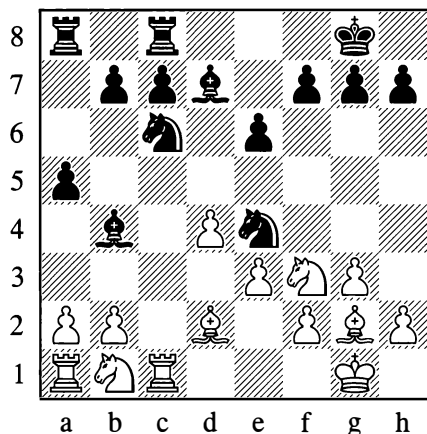
10.♟xc4 ♘xc4 11.e3 ♙d7

The main alternative here is 11...♘xd2, when my preference is to recapture with the f3-knight. 12.♘fxd2 a4 occurred in Garcia Palermo – Marin, Benasque 2010, and now 13.0–0N ♙d7 14.♟c1 0–0 15.♘e4 ♟a5 16.♘a3 would promise White nice pressure on the queenside.

12.0–0 0–0 13.♟c1! ♟fc8?

Relatively better is 13...♘xd2 14.♘bxd2 a4, but White retains an advantage after: 15.a3 ♙d6 16.♘c4 ♘a5 17.♘fd2!±

The text was played in Baumbach – Gudyev, corr. 1987, and here White missed a powerful continuation:

**14.♙xb4!N axb4 15.♘e5 ♘xe5 16.dxe5**

Winning at least a pawn.

D2) 7...♙xd2† 8.♟xd2

8.♘bxd2 b5 9.a4 c6 allows Black to hang on to the c4-pawn.

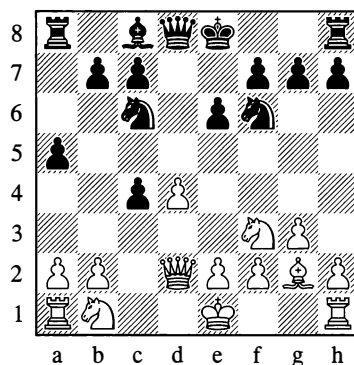
8...c6

Black's first choice by far, however I would also like to mention some other possibilities:

8...b5 runs into 9.♟g5! – one of the ideas behind the ♟xd2 recapture. 9...0–0 10.♟xb5 ♙a6 11.♟xa5 ♘bd7 was Laznicka – Kosten,

Austria 2008, and here White would have been left with a healthy extra pawn after: 12.0–0N ♟b8 13.♟d2±

8...♘c6 was L'Ami – Balogh, Germany 2007. I think this was an opportune moment for:



9.♘a3!N A possible continuation is 9...♘e4 10.♟c2 ♘d6 11.♘xc4 ♘b4 12.♟b3 ♘d5 (12...♘xc4 13.♟xc4 b6 14.♘e5 ♙a6 15.♟c3 is unpleasant for Black) 13.0–0 0–0 14.♟fe1 a4 15.♟c2 ♘xc4 16.♟xc4± White has an obvious advantage.

8...♙d7 9.♘e5 ♙c6 10.♘xc6 ♘xc6 11.♘a3 0–0

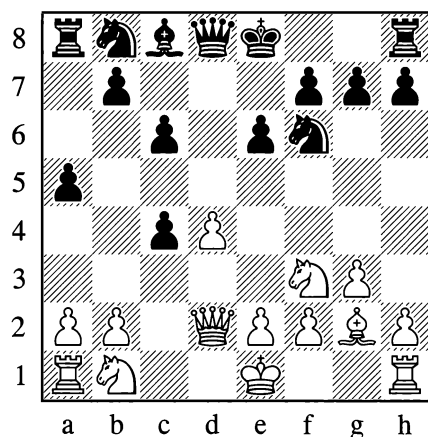
After 11...♘xd4 12.♙xb7 ♟b8 13.♙g2 0–0, which happened in Huzman – Vul, Montreal 2007, White could have secured a clear advantage with: 14.♘xc4N c5 15.e3 ♘f5 16.♙d1!±

12.e3 ♘b4

Faure – Soldano, corr. 2013, continued 12...♟e8, and now the best continuation would have been: 13.♘xc4N e5 14.0–0 exd4 15.exd4 ♙d8 16.♟fe1 ♟d7 17.d5. White is better after both 17...♘b4 18.d6! and 17...♘d5 18.♙ad1 ♘ce7 19.♟xa5.

13.♘xc4 c5?! 14.a3 ♘bd5 15.0–0

White is clearly better, as Black has no compensation for the pressure along the h1-a8 diagonal. White went on to win in Delchev – Giorgadze, Olite 2006.

**9.a4**

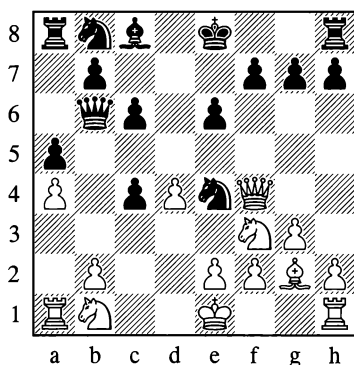
White is planning to regain the pawn by means of $\text{d}3\text{xc4}$ with a thematic edge.

$9.\text{d}e5$ $b5$ doesn't promise anything for White.

We have reached another split, with Black's two options being **D21)** $9...\text{d}e4$ and **D22)** $9...b5$.

D21) $9...\text{d}e4$ $10.\text{f}4$ $\text{d}d6$ **$10...\text{f}b6$**

An interesting alternative, which has occurred in several correspondence games. Here I have a new proposal:

 **$11.0-0!?N$**

Black is fine after $11.\text{d}bd2$ $\text{d}xd2$ $12.\text{f}xd2$ $\text{d}d7$.

 $11...\text{f}xb2$ $12.\text{d}e5$ $0-0$

$12...f6?!$ $13.\text{d}xc4$ $\text{f}xa1$ $14.\text{f}xe4$ looks scary for Black.

 $13.\text{d}a3$ $\text{d}c3$ $14.\text{f}e3$ $\text{d}d7$

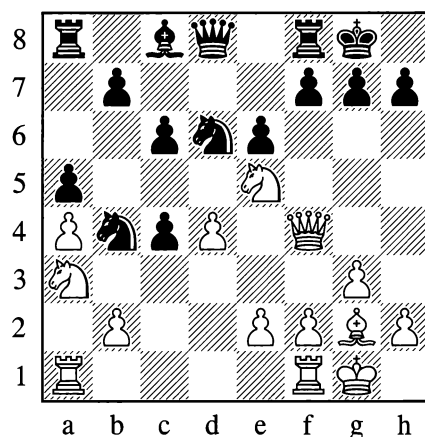
After $14...\text{d}xe2+$ $15.\text{g}h1$ $\text{d}c3$, the best way to trap the black queen is: $16.\text{d}axc4$ $\text{f}b4$ $17.\text{f}c1$ $\text{d}d5$ $18.\text{g}xd5$ exd5 $19.\text{d}d3$ $\text{f}xc4$ $20.\text{f}xc4$ dxc4 $21.\text{d}f4$ White is better.

 $15.\text{d}exc4$ $\text{f}b4$ $16.\text{f}d3$ $\text{d}d5$ $17.e4$ $\text{f}c3$ $18.\text{f}d1!$

I think it's important for White to avoid the queen swap, in order to have chances to seize the initiative on the kingside.

 $18...\text{d}b4$ $19.e5$ $\text{f}d3$ $20.\text{f}g4$

White's compensation is obvious.

 $11.\text{d}a3$ $\text{d}a6$ $12.\text{d}e5$ $0-0$ $13.0-0$ $\text{d}b4$  **$14.\text{f}d1!N$**

I believe this is more accurate than $14.\text{d}axc4$ $\text{d}xc4$ $15.\text{d}xc4$ $b6$, when Black had a solid position in Cioara – Landa, Baden-Baden 2012.

 $14...f6$

By provoking this move White makes the e6-pawn a potential target for the future.

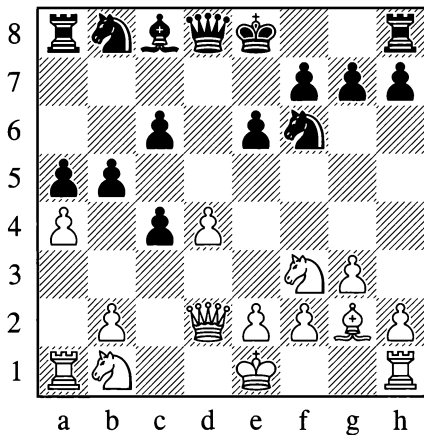
After $14...\text{d}d5$ $15.\text{f}c1$ $\text{d}b6$ $16.\text{f}c2!?$ $\text{g}d7$ $17.\text{d}exc4$ $\text{d}dxc4$ $18.\text{d}xc4$ $\text{d}xc4$ $19.\text{f}xc4$ the difference in the power of the light-squared

bishops is noticeable, and should give White a long-lasting pull.

**15.♟exc4 ♟xc4 16.♟xc4 b6 17.♞d2 ♟a6
18.b3 ♟a7 19.e4 ♞d7 20.♞ad1**

Black is still solid, but White's space advantage is beyond doubt.

D22) 9...b5



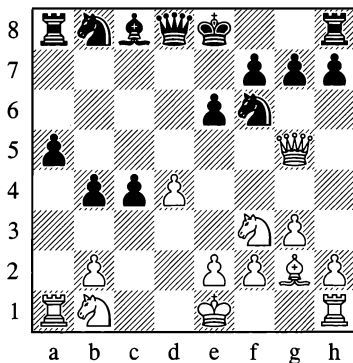
This position has been contested at the highest level, so it is important to go into some detail.

10.axb5 cxb5 11.♞g5

The point behind 8.♞xd2.

11...0-0

Only one game has seen 11...b4 and, despite White's crushing win after 12.♟e5, I prefer:



12.♞xg7N (After 12.♟e5 in Harutjunyan – Poghosyan, Yerevan 2014, Black missed the surprising 12...h6!N, when the g7-pawn is untouchable in view of 13...♞h7, and instead 13.♞f4 ♟a7 14.♟xc4 ♟a6 leads to double-edged play.) 12...♞g8 13.♞h6 ♟b7 14.♟bd2 The black king's miserable position should eventually tell.

12.♞xb5 ♟a6

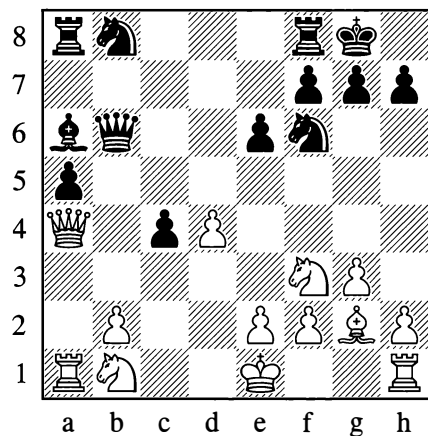
12...♟a6?! fails to work and after 13.♞xc4 (13.♟bd2!? is also interesting) 13...♟b4 14.♞b3 e5 15.♟xe5 ♞b8 16.0-0 ♞xd4 17.♞xa5 ♟e6 18.♞c3 Black was just two pawns down in Grischuk – Moiseenko, Sochi 2006.

13.♞a4

I undertook a detailed investigation of this line in 2006 during my work with Vladimir Kramnik, and found that 13.♞xa5 doesn't give White an advantage in view of: 13...♟b7 14.♞xd8 ♞xa1! 15.♞xf8† ♟xf8 16.0-0 ♟a2 The game should end peacefully.

13...♞b6!

Black must play actively to compensate for his pawn weaknesses.

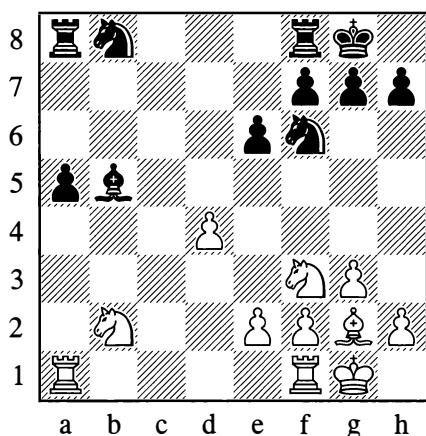


14.0-0

14.♟bd2 ♟b5 15.♞a3 ♟c6 16.0-0 ♞ab8 is dead level; which was proven in Leko – Kramnik, Dortmund 2009.

14...♖xb2 15.♘bd2 ♘b5 16.♘xc4 ♘xa4
17.♘xb2 ♘b5!

After a fairly forcing sequence of moves, we have reached a double-edged endgame. White's idea is to coordinate his pieces with the help of his powerful bishop and try to attack Black's a5-pawn – which can be a serious weakness under some circumstances. Black mostly relies on active piece counterplay, as was seen in the Kramnik – Topalov World Championship match.



18.♘d2?

I have to confess that I was the first one to discover these sequences back in 2006, an accomplishment which I am proud of. I was shocked when Vladimir Kramnik asked me to analyse this position in detail on the first day of our training camp before his match with Topalov, but his instincts were accurate – the position arose in the very first game!

18.♘d2?

This move is not without venom, and has been employed twice by Gupta.

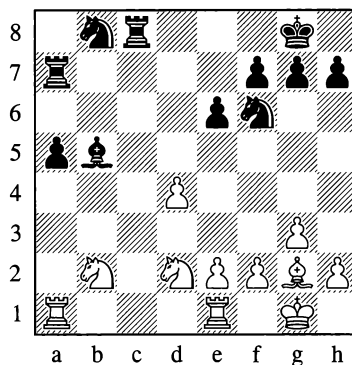
18...♞a7

This looks like the best move for Black, since after 18...♞c6?! 19.♘b3 ♘xc6 20.♘xc6 ♘bd7 21.♘xa5 Black lost his passed pawn surprisingly quickly in Gupta – Greenfeld, Chennai 2011.

19.♞fe1 ♞c8

19...♘c6 20.e3 ♘b4 21.♞eb1 allows White to comfortably regroup.

Here I found an interesting idea:



20.e3N

20.♘a4 ♘bd7 21.e3 was Gupta – Maheswaran, Kochi 2011. Black should now have played 21...♘xa4!N 22.♞xa4 ♘b6, followed by 23...a3, when it is hard to see White's advantage.

20...♘bd7

20...♞c2 21.♞eb1! The point. Now 21...♘bd7 transposes to 20...♘bd7, while after 21...♞xd2 22.♘c4 Black would have to play: 22...♞d1! 23.♞xd1 ♘xc4 24.♞dc1 ♘a6 25.♞xa5 The endgame is quite unpleasant for Black.

21.♞eb1 ♞c2 22.♘e4 ♘c6 23.♘xf6† gxf6

23...♘xf6 24.♘xc6 ♞xc6 25.♘d3! and the white knight comes to c5.

24.♘xc6 ♞xc6 25.♘a4 f5 26.♞a2

White retains a slight pull here, as Black is doomed to defend passively. This all happened because White managed to block Black's pawn on a5.

18...♞a7

A clearly worse alternative is: 18...♞a6?! 19.♘bd3 ♘bd7 20.♞fb1 ♘xe5?! (20...♘xd3 was preferable, although White is still better after 21.♘xd3) 21.♘c5! This is why the rook is so miserably placed on a6. Meier – Wojtaszek,

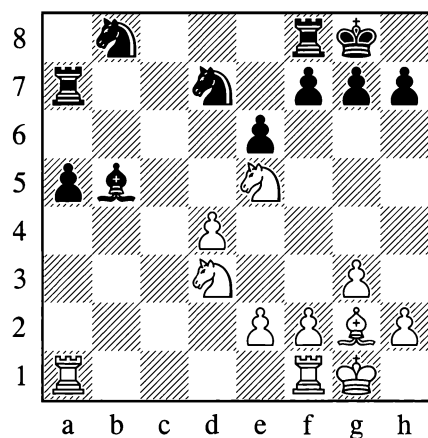
Novi Sad 2009, continued 21...♟c6!
(21...♟ed7 22.♞xb5 ♟xc5 23.dxc5 a4 24.♟b7
♞a7 25.♞b4 would be hopeless, according to
Meier) and now most convincing is Meier's
recommendation from *ChessBase Magazine*
133: 22.♟xc6!N ♞xc6 23.♞xb5 ♞e8 24.f4! Not
even allowing 24...e5.

19.♟bd3

19.♟f3 ♟bd7 20.♟ec4 ♞b8 21.♞fb1 g5!
gave Black lots of counterplay in Kramnik –
Topalov, Elista (1) 2006.

19...♟fd7

Much worse is: 19...♟bd7 20.♟c6!N
(20.♞fb1 ♟xe5 21.♞xb5 ♟xd3 22.exd3 was
drawish in Ushenina – T. Kosintseva, Rijeka
2010.) 20...♟xc6 (20...♞c7 21.♞fc1! forces
the exchange on c6 anyway, but in a worse
version for Black.) 21.♟xc6 ♞c8 22.♞fc1±
White is better as his light-squared bishop is
too powerful.

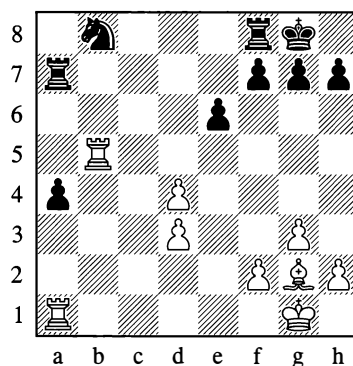


20.♞fb1!

Absolutely harmless is: 20.♟f3 ♟xe5
21.♟xe5 ♟d7!

20...♟xe5 21.♞xb5 ♟xd3 22.exd3 ♞d8

22...a4 has also been tried, and here I like:

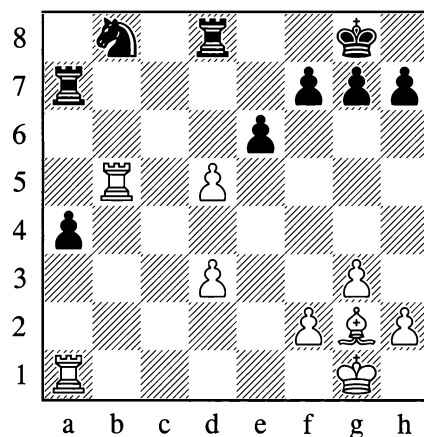


23.d5!N I believe only this move, which Cox
does not mention in his QGD repertoire
book, promises White winning chances. (In
the game Gleizerov – Luther, Predeal 2007,
White went for 23.♞a3 ♟d7 24.♟c6 ♟f6
25.♞b4 ♞d8 26.♞axa4 ♞xa4 27.♞xa4 ♟f8=
and despite winning the pawn it's an easy
draw for Black, as Cox correctly points out.)
23...exd5 24.♟xd5 ♞d8 25.♞b4!± White wins
a pawn and has a fifty/fifty chance between
winning and drawing.

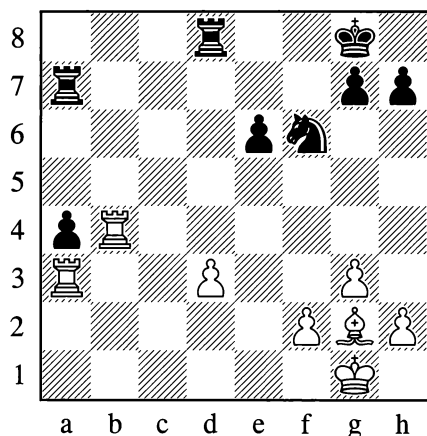
23.d5 a4

23...exd5 24.♟xd5 a4 25.♞b4 would
transpose to the above note.

The text was played in Ki. Georgiev – Pavasovic,
Valjevo 2007, and now White should have
played:



24.dxe6 N fxe6 25.♖a3! ♜d7 26.♝b4 ♜f6



27.♙f3

Sooner or later the a4-pawn will fall and we will reach another fifty/fifty endgame, which would be no fun at all for Black to defend.

Conclusion

This chapter saw some significant changes from *GM 1*, with the first coming in the variation 6.♙d2 c5 7.♙xb4 cxb4 8.♜e5 0–0. I now suggest 9.a3!?, which I originally prepared while working with Boris Gelfand – who employed it to win a model game against Adams at the 2012 European Club Cup. Further ideas have been tried from Black's side, but two improvements over the games of the young Ukrainian Grandmaster Andrey Baryshpolets have convinced me that White is doing well here.

The second major change arrived after 6.♙d2 a5, where I proposed 7.0–0 in *GM 1*. This time I am suggesting 7.♝c2, having found some new ideas which give White every chance to fight for an advantage. This is an extremely solid line for Black and there are no easy answers – but my analyses show the ideas and subtleties required for White to turn the game in a favourable direction.